But with reports surfacing that hundreds have got jobs reserved for tribals—for which cut-offs are comparatively lower—using dummy candidates, the government is in a fix. Cancelling all such exams will mean also punishing many legitimate and deserving recruits. A more fine-tuned approach is being adopted to zero in on the guilty even as efforts are under way to develop foolproof mechanisms for future examinations. Explaining this approach, V.K. Singh, additional director general of police (ADGP), SOG, says: "Whether the exams were cancelled due to a leak or not, we are identifying for prosecution as many candidates as possible who used leaked question papers or forged degrees, those involved in leaking the papers or posing as dummy candidates. The government aims to create a fear of law as the biggest deterrent."

The SOG's probe has led to the arrest of 35 trainee sub-inspectors (SIs) accused of benefitting from leaked papers, including the son of a deputy superintendent of police. "One shudders to imagine what kind of police officers they would have turned out to be with access to arms," says ADGP Singh, who has recommended that the Rajasthan Public Service Commission and the Rajasthan Subordinate and Ministerial Services Selection Board verify documents of successful candidates before issuing appointment letters. This was after his team found thousands of suspect cases of fake university degrees and disability and sports certificates.

The irregularities extend beyond exam leaks. Private universities have been implicated for issuing backdated degrees to candidates who never attended courses. Such complaints have surfaced earlier as well, but little headway was ever made. Subir Kumar, principal secretary for higher and technical education, outlines new measures: "We are serious this time about curbing such practices in private universities. The government is empowered to have its administrator posted in private universities that flout our norms and can even dissolve the institution." While students and parents have been advised to verify whether the institutes are permitted to run the courses being offered, the 53 private universities in the state have been ordered to furnish details of courses and the number of students who are enrolled and have graduated since inception to prevent the issuance of backdated degrees. While all past and current details of admissions and availability of seats are to be uploaded on university websites, money transactions have to be carried out digitally.



ANI

THE STATE GOVERNMENT HAS ORDERED A REVIEW OF THE SELECTION RECORDS OF SOME 125,000 EMPLOYEES RECRUITED DURING GEHLOT'S RULE

Even the sports department is developing a mechanism to verify certificates from educational institutions and sports bodies, so that only legitimate candidates can avail of extra marks or reservations. Investigations have revealed that about a thousand physical training instructors obtained jobs using fraudulent degrees and certificates last year. Similar vigilance has been advised for the issuance of disability certificates.

Amid these corrective measures, the SOG continues to investigate 2,000-plus complaints received via a dedicated helpline. While seven people were apprehended for issuing fake degrees from Mewar University in Chittorgarh, the arrest of Tulsa Ram and his nephew Pourav Kaler unearthed further details of a multi-examination paper leakage racket. The accused reportedly used Bluetooth devices hidden in footwear, buttons, collars, undergarments and even wigs to relay answers to examinees for substantial 'fees'. Gang members included individuals who specialised in clearing various exams as dummy candidates, either through merit or unfair means. The alleged kingpin, Suresh Dhaka, who ran coaching academies, remains at large.

Tulsa Ram's case exposed the depth of the rot. A former SI dismissed for irregularities, he opened coaching institutes in Jodhpur and Bikaner and now faces 14 criminal cases. Among others, he allegedly helped his nephew cheat on the SI exam in 2010 and was briefly arrested in 2014. His wife's sister, who is a trainee SI accused in the paper leak case, is absconding. The SOG has also identified and arrested members of another gang led by Jagdish Bishnoi besides one Praveen Kumar Bishnoi, who resigned as a senior auditor in 2023 and is accused of solving question papers for various gangs. Meanwhile, Unique Bhambu, a trainee forest ranger who is the alleged key conspirator in multiple paper leaks, including for the recruitment of junior engineers in 2021, is absconding.

The implications of this systemic corruption are far-reaching. As ADGP Singh notes, "Anyone selected in a government job using illegal means, often by spending huge money, cannot be expected to be doing his job honestly later on." Even as the government works to root out fraud and implement stricter controls, the challenge remains immense. In the meantime, the future of millions of government job aspirants and the integrity of Rajasthan's public institutions hang in the balance. ■